

Chapter 155_1 - Jade Nectar

Chu Qingqiu had been melancholy for a long time, and now with heart fire entering her organs, she fainted.

When she woke again, bright candles flickered beside her. The dim yellow light enveloped the entire rosewood and porcelain arhat bed¹, with the scent of wood mixed with candlelight quietly drifting into her nostrils.

The palace was silent except for the crackling of flames - no other sounds could be heard.

Chu Qingqiu hurriedly sat up, lifting off the dark cloak draped over her chest. As her bare feet touched the ground, she met someone's gaze - a calm look that glanced at her once before closing again.

The dust that had risen in Chu Qingqiu's heart slowly settled under this gaze.

"You're awake." Ning Fuyi, who sat cross-legged on a screen table² facing her, spoke.

Chu Qingqiu didn't reply, still staring intently at her face. The dim firelight made her features appear even more profound, with an exotic kind of allure.

"What's your name?" Ning Fuyi asked.

Chu Qingqiu's red lips moved slightly, finally testing the waters as she spoke: "Chu Qingqiu."

She carefully observed Ning Fuyi's expression, hoping to see even the slightest anomaly in that unchanging demeanor, but there was nothing. Those phoenix eyes remained closed, as if the name had no connection to her whatsoever.

"Not pleasant to hear, too cold." Ning Fuyi's dark brows furrowed. "I'll give you a new name from now on - call you Little White³."

Though Chu Qingqiu hadn't yet emerged from her sorrow, she was still provoked by this name to clench her fists: "What?"

"Little White." Ning Fuyi impatiently repeated. "This lord won't take your ancestral surname, just change the given name - Chu Little White."

The palace remained silent, while the white jade flute⁴ at "Little White's" waist began to hum involuntarily.

When Ning Fuyi's sharp gaze struck, Chu Qingqiu forcibly suppressed White Bone's⁵ anger, her knuckles turning blue-white from gripping so hard, before finally nodding.

"Fine," she said.

"You have some sense." Ning Fuyi closed her eyes again, circulating her demonic power three times around her body before it settled in her dantian⁶. Only after completing her cultivation did she rise with hands behind her back and walk before Chu Qingqiu.

"The clothes don't look good either - all white and flowery, completely out of place with this lord's demon cavern." The more Ning Fuyi looked at those clothes, the more displeased she became. She reached out to grab the fabric, but it was too cool and slippery to hold.

"Change them," she commanded.

Chu Qingqiu nearly couldn't control White Bone's trembling. Finally, she secretly cast a spell to seal White Bone before enduring it.

"I saw the red dress that qilin⁷ wore yesterday - quite nice, making her more delicate than flowers." Ning Fuyi gestured in front of the woman, measuring her proportions before manifesting a stack of dresses. Even undergarments were completely prepared on top.

Looking at that fire-red bellyband⁸, Chu Qingqiu's face flushed red. She raised her hand wanting to strike her with a stick, but she was holding back her strength while Ning Fuyi moved quickly, seizing White Bone with her other hand and tossing it aside.

Her other hand twisted both of Chu Qingqiu's hands behind her back, restraining her.

How detestable was Ning Fuyi after losing her memory? The angrier Chu Qingqiu became, the more she remembered how good the former Ning Fuyi had been. Grief surged up, and she felt faint again.

Having to stay close to the woman due to their positions, Ning Fuyi was momentarily overwhelmed by the gardenia fragrance. The floral scent soothed her heart, inexplicably calming the restless melancholy that had been troubling her.

Moreover, this woman was truly beautiful. Among all the people she'd seen since awakening, she'd thought that qilin was the pinnacle of beauty, but unexpectedly this woman, though full of pride and difficult to get along with, was even more beautiful than the qilin.

Such a face, and her fragrance - it would be a waste to kill her.

So Ning Fuyi released her grip. The woman before her went soft for a moment, grasping her wrist before stepping back to steady herself.

"Here." Ning Fuyi stuffed the clothes into her arms. "Change."

After speaking, she turned and opened the door. Her tall figure quickly disappeared behind it, the sound of her flowing cloud boots⁹ on the ground gradually fading.

Chu Qingqiu stood alone in the dim candlelight, holding the fragrant clothes, not knowing what she was thinking. After a while, the door was pulled open and a woman in red slipped in.

"Divine Venerable, how are things?" Jiuying¹⁰ crept over to her side, glancing at Chu Qingqiu's reddened eyes and then at the boldly styled clothes in her hands, clicking her tongue.

"Was she like this when she woke up?" Chu Qingqiu's voice trembled slightly as she asked in a deep voice.

"She's been like this since awakening - remembers nothing, but basic social graces haven't been forgotten." Jiuying sighed. "Everyone in the Demon Realm has tried to awaken her memories, but nothing has worked."

"If we say too much, she gets annoyed and wants to kill people. So over time, no one dares mention anything about her past life."

Speaking of this, Jiuying changed the subject: "But what doesn't work for others might work for the Divine Venerable."

"This is also why I overcame all obstacles to forcibly bring the Divine Venerable into the Demon Realm." Jiuying said softly, her phoenix eyes curving. "She goes to the demon market¹¹ every afternoon now to listen to music."

"Take care." Jiuying handed her a blue feather before withdrawing again.

Chu Qingqiu waited quietly for a moment, then obediently changed into the dress she held. The dress looked improper, but when actually worn, it wasn't as frivolous as imagined.

The sleeves were light and airy, revealing half her lotus-root arms. The sash at her waist fit snugly, exposing her waist that had become a circle thinner in the candlelight. The skirt hem was like blooming poppy flowers, layer upon layer cascading down.

Bright as the moon among clouds, sinking into blooming flowers.

Chu Qingqiu bent down to pick up White Bone that Ning Fuyi had thrown aside, took a deep breath, and walked out of the demon cavern.

The blue feather Jiuying gave her floated before her as soon as she left the door, like a lightweight guide leading her through the stone gates and courtyards of the demon cavern, across streams flowing with pitch-black liquid, into the crimson sky of the Demon Realm.

Chu Qingqiu wasn't unfamiliar with the Demon Realm, but she'd never strolled leisurely like this. In the past, demons would roar and pounce at strangers, but the blue feather would emit a ghostly red light, driving the demonic creatures away.

Over time, that red light had enveloped Chu Qingqiu, converting all her aura to demonic breath and blending her into the demon crowds - more useful than Chu Qingqiu's own divine artifact.

Footnotes:

¹ **Arhat bed (罗汉床)** - A traditional Chinese daybed/couch, named after the Buddhist arhats who were often depicted reclining on such furniture.

- ² **Screen table (屏几)** - A low table with decorative screens, often used for meditation or displaying objects.
- ³ **Little White (小白)** - A dismissive/casual nickname, literally meaning "little white one," often used for pets or in a condescending manner.
- ⁴ **White jade flute (白玉笛)** - Refers to Chu Qingqiu's weapon, White Bone, which can take the form of a flute.
- ⁵ **White Bone (白骨)** - Chu Qingqiu's divine weapon that has consciousness and emotions.
- ⁶ **Dantian (丹田)** - In Chinese martial arts and cultivation, the energy center in the lower abdomen where spiritual energy is stored.
- ⁷ **Qilin (麒麟)** - Refers to Jiuying, who is associated with the mythical qilin creature.
- ⁸ **Bellyband (肚兜)** - A traditional Chinese undergarment covering the chest and stomach area.
- ⁹ **Flowing cloud boots (流云靴)** - Elegant boots, likely with cloud-like decorative patterns.
- ¹⁰ **Jiuying (九婴)** - Character name referring to a nine-headed mythical beast.
- ¹¹ **Demon market (魔市)** - A marketplace within the Demon Realm where demons gather to trade and socialize.